1994 immigrants, though, tended to have closer family ties, and more nuanced politics. Even if they considered themselves opponents of the Cuban government, they saw the restrictions as an attack on the Cuban people, not the regime.

In 2000, candidate Bush received 82 percent of the 450,000 Cuban American votes in Florida. In 2004, after the new restrictions were put into place, polls found his support dipping to between 60 and 70 percent. Among Cubans born in the United States, only 32 percent supported the president. “We older Cubans lived inside the monster, and we know that you have to keep fighting that old dictator. That’s what President Bush plans to do,” one older Cuban immigrant explained, justifying his support for Bush. “The president is asking us to choose between ideology and family. It’s a stupid question. Don’t make me choose,” countered a younger man, announcing that he, for one, intended to vote for Kerry.[38] Another recent immigrant added, in 2008, “I don’t think of the people there as pawns for us to play with … They include my parents. They include my sister. I truly feel for them. I don’t want to hurt the Cuban government if it’s going to hurt them.”[39]

Cuba, Venezuela, and the ALBA

The election of Hugo Chávez in Venezuela in 1998 significantly changed the dynamic of inter-American relations. Cuba had never been quite as isolated as U.S. policymakers suggested. In the Third World and among non-aligned countries, Cuba was a leader and the United States more often than not isolated; even among U.S. allies, none followed the U.S. lead in cutting off relations with the island. Still, Susan Eckstein could reasonably argue, in a chapter entitled “From Communist Solidarity to Communist Solitary”, that, compounding the loss of the Soviet bloc, “Cuba in the early 1990s also faced difficulties with its Latin American neighbors. Cuba lost regional allies when a U.S. intervention ousted Panama’s Gen. Manuel Noriega in December 1989 and when the Sandinistas were defeated in the February 1990 Nicaraguan elections.”[40] Just over a decade later, it was clearly the